The Rafe Courier

SATURDAY, 17 OCTOBER 2026 · NO. 12 · ISLAMABAD 24°C, SUNNY

TOP STORIES

Central banks edge towards a synchronised pause as inflation cools faster than forecast

PRIYA NATARAJAN · FINANCIAL TIMES · FT.COM



Policymakers in Washington, Frankfurt and London signalled this week that the long cycle of rate rises is over, after consumer price data showed inflation falling for a fifth straight month.

Three things to know

1. Rates: the Fed, ECB and Bank of England are all signalling a pause.
2. Sindh: water is draining, but 1.2 million people still need homes.
3. Cricket: Babar's 127* puts Pakistan 187 ahead in Multan.

SCAN TO READ THE LEAD STORY AT FT.COM

EDITOR'S NOTE

Good morning, Rafe. Central banks are finally in step, the floods in Sindh are receding but the bills are not, and Babar is batting in Multan. I kept the markets coverage short today and gave cricket more room, since you opened every match report last week.

TOP STORIES

Floods recede in Sindh, but the harder work of rebuilding is only beginning

DAWN · DAWN.COM

Three weeks after the monsoon breached embankments along the Indus, water has drained from most affected...

PAKISTAN

Karachi's new bus rapid transit line opens to riders, to mixed reviews

DAWN · DAWN.COM

The 26-kilometre Red Line carried 90,000 passengers on its first working day, officials said, but commuters...

IN BRIEF

UN climate envoy urges richer nations to double adaptation finance. Speaking in Nairobi, the envoy said current pledges leave... REUTERS

Oil steadies near $78 as Gulf supply fears ease. Brent crude held a narrow range after talks eased concerns over shipping routes. BLOOMBERG

TOP STORIES

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A quiet breakthrough in battery chemistry could cut electric-car prices by a fifth

MIT TECHNOLOGY REVIEW · TECHNOLOGYREVIEW.COM

Researchers at a Swedish start-up say a new sodium-based cell matches the energy density of today's lithium packs at a much lower cost, using materials that are abundant and easy to source. Carmakers have signed evaluation deals, and the first vehicles could reach showrooms within two years if pilot production goes to plan.

IN BRIEF

Heathrow to trial AI-assisted baggage screening next month. The airport says passengers will no longer need to remove laptops at two terminals. BBC NEWS

PAKISTAN

THE RAFE COURIER

State Bank holds policy rate at 11% and flags food prices

BUSINESS RECORDER · BRECORDER.COM

The central bank said headline inflation is easing but food costs remain volatile, and kept the policy rate unchanged for the third meeting in a row. Analysts expect a cut by the end of the year if the rupee holds.

Islamabad's tech parks court foreign start-ups with tax breaks

THE EXPRESS TRIBUNE · TRIBUNE.COM.PK

A new package offers a five-year income-tax holiday to companies that hire at least 50 local engineers, part of a wider push to turn the capital into a regional software hub.

IN BRIEF

Lahore smog levels fall after rain. Air quality improved overnight but remains unhealthy for sensitive groups. GEO NEWS

Rupee gains marginally against the dollar. The currency closed at 278.4 in the interbank market. DAWN

TECHNOLOGY & AI

Open-weight models close the gap with the frontier, and enterprises are noticing

BENJ EDWARDS · ARS TECHNICA · ARSTECHNICA.COM



A new generation of freely downloadable language models now matches proprietary systems on many coding and reasoning benchmarks, prompting companies to reconsider how much they spend on API access. Vendors respond by cutting prices and bundling tools, but security teams say hosting models in-house brings its own risks, from supply-chain attacks to prompt-injection exposure.

Why your phone's battery health matters less than you think

THE VERGE · THEVERGE.COM

Engineers say software throttling, not capacity, explains most of the slowdowns users blame on ageing cells. A fresh install and a cooler pocket often help more than a replacement battery.

Start-up raises $40m to automate customer-support calls in Urdu

TECHCRUNCH · TECHCRUNCH.COM

The Karachi company says its voice agents now resolve a majority of routine banking queries without a human, and plans to expand to Arabic and Bengali next year.

IN BRIEF

Chip makers brace for new export rules. Shares in major suppliers fell after the draft was leaked. REUTERS

Linux kernel adds support for the next-generation Wi-Fi standard. Developers merged the drivers after months of review. HACKER NEWS

SPORT

THE RAFE COURIER

Babar's century anchors Pakistan to a commanding lead in Multan

ESPNCRICINFO · ESPNCRICINFO.COM



Pakistan closed the second day at 412 for 4, a lead of 187, after a patient century from Babar Azam and a brisk half-century from Rizwan. The visitors' spinners found turn late in the day, but captain Masood said the plan is to bat on and give the bowlers a full day to attack.

Verstappen takes pole in Austin after late red flag

AUTOSPORT · AUTOSPORT.COM

The Dutchman edged Norris by 0.04 seconds in a session stopped twice, with the title fight still wide open.

IN BRIEF

Arsenal extend lead with 2-0 win at Villa. Goals either side of half-time sealed the points. BBC SPORT

Pakistan women book World Cup semi-final berth. A six-wicket win over Sri Lanka sealed qualification. ESPNCRICINFO

SCIENCE

THE RAFE COURIER

Webb telescope spots the faintest galaxy yet, only 290 million years after the Big Bang

NATURE NEWS · NATURE.COM

Astronomers using the James Webb Space Telescope have confirmed a compact, star-forming galaxy that existed when the universe was barely two per cent of its present age. The object is far smaller than expected, suggesting that galaxies began assembling earlier and more efficiently than standard models predict.

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Gut bacteria may explain why some people respond better to flu vaccines

SCIENCE DAILY · SCIENCEDAILY.COM

A study of 600 volunteers found that those with higher levels of certain microbes produced stronger antibody responses, hinting at a cheap way to boost protection with diet or probiotics.

IN BRIEF

Deep-sea mining pause extended by regulators. The authority delayed a decision on commercial licences until next year. BBC NEWS

CULTURE

THE RAFE COURIER

The return of the long-playing record, and what it says about how we listen

THE GUARDIAN · THEGUARDIAN.COM

Vinyl sales have overtaken CDs for the third year running, driven less by nostalgia than by a desire for attention. Record-shop owners say younger customers want something to hold, sleeve notes to read and an album to hear from start to finish. Streaming services, in turn, are experimenting with features that reward listening in order.

> *Record-shop owners say younger customers want something to hold, sleeve notes to read and an album to hear from start to finish.*

IN BRIEF

Booker shortlist features first Pakistani-born writer in a decade. The judges praised the novel's restraint. THE GUARDIAN

OUTSIDE YOUR BUBBLE

THE RAFE COURIER

How Japan quietly became the world's top recycler of plastic bottles

BBC FUTURE · BBC.COM

Something far from your usual reading.

Outside the headlines, a patchwork of local rules and cultural habits means more than 90 per cent of bottles in Japan are collected and reused. Residents rinse, strip labels and sort into as many as 20 categories, a routine many treat as a point of civic pride. Visitors are often surprised that there are almost no public bins.

The mathematician who proved a 60-year-old conjecture on her kitchen table

QUANTA MAGAZINE · QUANTAMAGAZINE.ORG

Working alone during a sabbatical, Maryam Karimi found a short argument for a problem that stumped specialists for decades. Peers are checking the proof, which uses ideas from an unrelated branch of geometry.

BEFORE YOU GO

THE RAFE COURIER

The morning quiz

1. Which sodium-based advance could cut electric-car prices by a fifth?

A Solid-state lithium
B Sodium-ion cells
C Hydrogen fuel cells
D Supercapacitors

2. How far above the Big Bang was the faintest galaxy Webb has found?

A 29 million years
B 290 million years
C 2.9 billion years

3. What did Pakistan's lead stand at on day two in Multan?

A 87 runs
B 187 runs
C 287 runs

Answers: 1-B, 2-B, 3-B

QUOTE OF THE DAY

“The true test will be whether the corridor stays clear of encroachment.”

DAWN

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